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CHICAGO TRANSIT AUTHORITY BOARD

Current chair part of mayor's nominees

Proposed picks mandated by state's transit funding and reform legislation

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson's nominees for the reconstituted Chicago Transit Authority board include two of the board's current members, including its chair.

Johnson's proposed transit board picks, which are subject to City Council approval, are mandated by the state's landmark transit funding and reform legislation, which took effect in June.

In addition to raising upward of \$1 billion a year for public transit, the law requires a shake-up of the boards that govern the CTA, Metra and Pace. The bill creates a new regional transit oversight body, the Northern Illinois Transit Authority, which is intended to be a more powerful version of the soon-to-be-defunct Regional Transportation Authority.

All current board members' terms expire on Sept. 1, when their replacements are expected to be seated.

But board members are allowed to be reappointed, and the majority of the mayor's picks already sit on one of the region's transit boards.

The mayor's nominees for the reconstituted CTA board include the board's current chair, Lester Barclay, an attorney who was originally appointed to the board by then-Mayor Lori Lightfoot. If approved by aldermen, Barclay would serve on both the CTA and NITA boards.

Barclay has previously criticized aspects of the new transit legislation — namely the increased oversight authority it gives to NITA.

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Grace Gumbiner and Sam Gainer outside their soon-to-be new home in a multiunit building in the 1700 block of North Damen Avenue on June 30 in Chicago. The engaged couple started looking to buy their first home in February. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'Demand is insatiable'

Summer homebuying season heats up, with packed open houses and offers above asking price

By S. Sorrina Beecher
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

To paint a picture of the Chicago-area housing market, visit an open house and look for the pile of shoes at the front door. That's where potential buyers — who frequently remove their shoes before walking through the home — start sizing up the competition.

Real estate agents and brokers say the Chicagoland market continues to be defined by intense buyer demand for a limited number of homes for sale. It's a market where homes are sometimes listed and then sold within

days, if not hours, and where potential buyers often need to make offers that are above the asking price in order to be successful.

Tommy Choi, co-founder and realtor at Keller Williams ONEChicago, says the Chicago housing market was unusually "aggressive," in the first half of the year. And agents say home prices — and competition — are expected to heat up even further this summer.

While the national housing market shows signs of cooling, the Chicago area, by all accounts, appears to be defying gravity.

"The Chicago narrative is pretty different from what we're hearing from around the country, in places like Florida or Arizona," says David Bracy, vice president at Berkshire Hathaway HomeServices Chicago, attributing the region's extreme seller's market to simple laws of supply and demand. "(There are) 20 to 40 people coming through an Open House. The amount of demand is insatiable."

First-time homebuyers Sam Gainer and his fiancée Grace Gumbiner, both 29, say they were unprepared for the cutthroat nature of Chicago real estate. The

couple jumped into the market to escape the rental cycle before turning 30, and to avoid the yearly rental increases that nearly priced them out of their beloved neighborhood of Bucktown.

"We went to nearly 25 open houses," Gainer explained, adding that they temporarily paused their search to reassess their budget and approach. "It was a very intimidating process. You would walk in and there would be 80 pairs of shoes at the front door, and then three or four offers by the end of the day."

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A ramp leading into the Deep Tunnel water reservoir north of the Thornton Quarry is partially submersed Monday following a rainy June and early July. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Nearly full Thornton reservoir brings sewage stink and increased flood risk

By Evy Lewis
and Olivia Stevens
DAILY SOUTHTOWN

With the Thornton Composite Reservoir near capacity for the first time in its history, south suburban residents are fearful of more flooding and some are sickened by the stench of sewage.

After the round of pouring rain that swept the suburbs over the weekend, the Thornton Composite Reservoir reached 94% capacity, the fullest it has been since becoming operational in 2015,

according to the Metropolitan Water Reclamation District of Greater Chicago.

As of 10:15 a.m. Tuesday, the water level had receded slightly from that high to 93% capacity, or 7.3 billion gallons, according to the district's website. The highest the reservoir has ever been before was in 2019, when it hit 54.5% capacity.

With billions of gallons of sewer water sitting open to the air, nearby residents have to deal with the stench.

"It smells," said Thornton Village Clerk Nikki Kitakis. "It's

pretty horrific."

Odors from the reservoir have been a long-standing issue for residents of Thornton, though Kitakis said the issue is particularly severe with the reservoir so full.

"The stench is putrid, and it affects all facets of life because it smells so terrible," Kitakis said. "I wish there was Smell-O-Vision so I could send a sample your way because it's, it's awful."

The water reclamation district has taken some measures to

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More Dems demand Platner quit campaign

Picking a successor in Maine's Senate race could divide the party

By Kimberlee Kruesi
and Patrick Whittle
ASSOCIATED PRESS

PORTLAND, Maine — Sen. Bernie Sanders on Tuesday became the latest and most notable lawmaker to pull support for Maine Democratic U.S. Senate nominee Graham Platner following an allegation of sexual assault, adding to a chorus of calls for him to step aside as party leaders scramble to determine the next steps.

Sanders, a Vermont independent who caucuses with Democrats, has long backed Platner in the high-stakes race against Republican Sen. Susan Collins, but he said in a statement that he spoke with the candidate and "in light of these very serious allegations, I have recommended that he step aside."



Democratic U.S. Senate candidate Graham Platner speaks during a primary election night watch party on June 9 in Blue Hill, Maine. **ROBERT F. BUKATY/AP**

Platner, who denies the allegation, has not heeded the calls to resign. Instead, he posted a video Monday saying he was considering the next steps for his campaign while canceling town hall events.

Platner posted the video after reports that a woman who previously dated the first-time candidate said he drunkenly forced her

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INSIDE

US strikes Iran after cargo ships hit

The U.S. military launched new strikes against Iran early Wednesday, hours after three merchant ships were struck in the Strait of Hormuz, threatening the interim deal to end the fighting between the two nations. **Nation & World, Page B4**



Still 'living the dream'

10 years later, former Cubs star Willson Contreras still loves being in the fight. **Paul Sullivan in Sports**

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